CAIMAN LIZARD

Dracaena guianensis

Think About This

What strength of yours costs you something?

What can I see or hear?

Heavy-bodied, semi-aquatic lizard with crocodile-like scaled back. Powerful jaws, short round teeth for crushing shells. Forked tongue. Strong swimmer, climbs branches over water.

Where does it live, and why?

Flooded woodlands and riverbanks of the Amazon Basin. Splits time between water (hunting, escape) and overhanging branches (basking, sleeping).

How does it send messages?

Bright body color signals between males and females. Forked tongue collects scent particles to locate prey, mates, and predators. Posturing in displays.

What does it do when something changes?

Dives readily when disturbed. Forages along banks during the day, hides in trees and bushes at night. Body adapts for life on land AND in water.

How does it learn?

Intelligent — observed solving problems, recognizing keepers, working out how to dislodge a snail clinging to rocks.

How does it have babies?

Female lays 5 to 10 eggs in a riverbank hole, covers them, leaves. ~179 day incubation. Hatchlings emerge fully independent — walk and swim within hours.

What are the limits?

Lifespan 10 to 12+ years in care. Specialized diet — wild-caught adults often refuse anything but snails. Needs warm humid forest with deep water access.

What does this teach us?

Specialists are powerful but fragile. The same jaws that crush shells lock this animal to a single food. Every strength has a cost.